1

COLLECTIVE ENACTMENTS, AFFECTIVE PREFIGURATIONS AND IMMERSIVE SPECULATIONS FOR ECO-SOCIAL CHANGE

Ann Light and Harry Lewis

Introduction

End-of-times have been predicted before, but never with the ecological data to track decline. Humankind appears to be trundling, knowingly, towards annihilation, taking with it many of its companion species. Normally cautious scientific communities have turned to more radical talk: overshoots and breaches (e.g., Ritchie et al., 2021; Taeoalii-Tipton, 2025), system change (e.g., Obura et al., 2026), degrowth (e.g., Krpan et al., 2025) and transformative adaptation (e.g., Fedele et al., 2019; Zurek et al., 2022). That times are changing – and, indeed, need to change – has become dinner table conversation across the world.

What is at stake is not only what people do, but how people understand themselves, their responsibilities and their possibilities. The converging consequences of industrial and colonial legacy are creating a time of heightened cultural awareness. The cracks in hyper-industrialised everyday life – across ecological, socio-technical and political realms – are exposing the limits of how dominant societies have been making sense of the world and acting in it. These crises are not just technical or economic problems to be solved; they are relational and existential in nature, turning focus towards the interdependencies underpinning life, the ongoing predicaments of living and the narratives we use to articulate these (Jasanoff, 2010; Kimmerer, 2013; Krenak, 2020; Yusoff & Gabrys, 2011).

Responses to the predicament at the level of policy remain inadequate, rooted in current thinking and vested interests. Anyone hearing the story of Big Oil's influence on the UN Climate Conferences of the 1980s and 1990s – now dramatised in the play *Kyoto* (Murphy & Robertson, 2025) – will rue how little has been achieved (since the same oil companies met to discuss the challenge of climate destruction in the 1950s), but not wonder why. By shifting responsibility onto

DOI: 10.4324/9781003660187-1
This chapter has been made available under a CC BY-ND 4.0 license.

individual consumers, these corporations advocated for small, symbolic gains, whilst obstructing the systemic transformation that the crisis demands (Supran & Oreskes, 2021). As a result, we have behavioural "nudging", awareness campaigns and individualised calls for action that bypass the deeper shifts needed – shifts in meaning-making and sense of belonging, relations with land and kinship across species. Furthermore, the limitations of these approaches are increasingly visible as conditions intensify: messaging fatigue; resistance to fear-based framings; a sense of futility in the face of complexity; and an embrace of leaders with simplistic blame narratives and survivalist fantasies (Klein & Taylor, 2025). This is compounded by a lack of leadership in moving towards worlds that people might want to live in from the ruined riches we inhabit (Haraway, 2016; Hine, 2023; Machado De Oliveira, 2021; Raven & Stripple, 2021; Tsing et al., 2017).

If the dominant present is marked by fragmentation and fatigue, our futures demand something different – something that stirs the imagination as much as it sharpens the will. Change will not emerge from data alone, nor from appeals to isolated individuals; it will grow from experiences that connect us to each other and to the worlds we wish to inhabit. The question is not simply what people should do, but how we – the many humans who have lost connection with the rhythms of the planet – learn to feel, think and act differently, together. More specifically, we can ask whether the means to inspire changes of this magnitude exist. Our answer is emphatic: yes – such means not only exist, but are being fatally overlooked. And, further, they are processes that bring joy, insight and new friendships, which are worth following for that journey alone.

The Collection

This collection makes a case for intimate, immersive, participatory and embodied practices as a means of travel towards futures that we want. Through experiences that are sensorial and evoking of emotion, artists and designers have been crafting spaces where positive alternative futures are not just imagined, they are enacted. Both embodied speculation and the collaborating that goes with it are moves towards futures that might improve life for the many. This is not only to resist projections of chaos and loss, but to improve on present worlds towards those where we might love, care and celebrate as we wish. From practical consultations to fantastical imaginings, via many creative devices, the work here starts with faith in the potential for engaged and engaging change created by people acting together. The collection exists to articulate how embedded creative practices can contribute to flourishing futures in a meeting of method and ethos.

The type of work described is not new in character, though some targets for it are. Instead, collecting these examples and explaining their value is *timely*, building relational capacity in the face of uncertainty to address the chasm between crisis and response in a potentially meaningful way. It is not the first argument

that the arts have much to contribute to cultural change (for instance, see Brown, 2014; Guaraldo, 2023; Lekkerkerk & Burgering, 2024; Lineberry & Wiek, 2016; Weintraub, 2012 for very different approaches to this). But the book focuses on how a cluster of related practices can be usefully life-changing, looking at what they share and what emerges as a powerful form if read together. We, in conjuring a collection into being, invite 'reading not only each contribution on its own, but […] across them, to juxtapose and to also get a sense of the tensions and spaces between them' (Giaccardi et al., 2025, p. 4). As Giaccardi and team say, the point is not to be comprehensive, but to offer illustrations of how works connect to each other as well as to the traditions and discourses they relate to (Giaccardi et al., 2025).

The collected approaches can be characterised as *immersive and participative* (and largely *speculative* and *embodied* too), where the combination of these qualities is fundamental to the outcomes. These practices invite intense experiences, offering – sometimes fast but effectively – the means of changing attitudes and of establishing collectives for making change. They respond to the need for new sources of meaning. They propose joined-up thinking that recognises climate care, mutual support and regenerative living beyond managing obvious harms. They work with what they find in place, for an evolution in how we, caught in post-industrial and hyper-technologised societies, conduct ourselves to engage with others, including with non-human living beings. Some approaches are explicitly *more-than-human*, adopting post-human (Braidotti, 2010) or New Materialist (Barad, 2007) philosophy and engaging with ecological systems as well as other species. All look compassionately and constructively at being human at a time of great reflexivity and change.

Bringing these related, but varied, practices into conversation with each other is both a very precise matter – we have invited skilled practitioners to analyse their mechanisms for working collaboratively in some detail – and a loose one – the ends that people aspire to, as designers, facilitators and participants, differ and so do their means of engagement. To be clear, we – the editors and the contributors across the book – are not looking for a consensus on flourishing futures or how to move towards them. *Flourishing* is a relative term: for some creatures to do well, others will be eaten. And we do not conceive of a single *future*. In fact, we know it is possible to work towards the wellbeing of the planet without ever choosing a specific destination or looking very far ahead. Some techniques included here never cite a/the future at all and others talk about little else. Some conceive of the temporal and make it a mainstay. Others pay no attention to philosophical aspects and concentrate on getting the work done. However, we share the *eco-social* understanding that we cannot separate the flourishing of human societies from the flourishing of ecologies and all the lives that we are entangled with, needing a cultural shift from extractivism and careless consumption to care for all life, and thus social, as well as climate, justice (see Houston et al., 2022). This is not to

ignore the fate of the many species we co-exist with, but to emphasise the potential of the *human* in our more-than-human worlds (Heitlinger et al., 2025) to act in the interest of all. What also unites the material included here is a sense of possibility, a joy in collaborative working and a belief that, through practice that supports people to find their agency together as a powerful and creative force, some change is already on its way.

The work also shares a commitment to a tier between the individual and "society" and across ideas of scale, being in neighbourhoods, temporary cities and world-spanning communities to address local expressions of global issues. This manifests as an approach that establishes and/or works with groups to help people achieve what is possible and desirable. In attempting to build on existing energy, we find allies in Escobar's idea of autonomia (Escobar, 2018), or Abdulla's designing otherwise (Abdulla, 2025). The orientation resists the myth of easy growth that comes as part of capitalist culture. Big schemes may struggle to attend to nuance, flattening place and character as part of seeking expansion. In the work we have chosen, actions build through repetition, care and attention to the accumulated historical detail that makes our worlds real to us, keeping relevance to land, place and culture (what Light and Catlow call *hyperlocal eco-social*, Chapter 13). This is the importance of attuning: maybe the difference between engagement and imposition.

Without recourse to scaling and monetising, we are left with questions of resourcing and how something so locally administered can be of use across wide areas. Such practices can spread through the proliferation of similar endeavours. In these cases, logics that stay local and emergent help people understand their own potential to make change; they draw attention to the link between local concerns and the global contexts and philosophical shifts that inform them. Yet, most of us in highly technologised environments (what Svendsen calls "high carbon culture" – Chapter 4) are wage slaves or worse; many people also lack the time to have vision and the confidence to join something as seemingly esoteric as an art or design initiative.[1] We have no single answer to how the processes described here can become more ubiquitously taken up. We see the book as part of making the case. We, the editors, encouraged the contributing authors to situate their work in issues of transformation and impact, next steps and worldly practice, rather than merely explaining techniques. We do not approach this field academically, in the sense of standing back, but as activists, concerned to make urgent change. Nonetheless, the book does not dwell on policy or implementation beyond a consideration of relevance, scope and types of effect. The nature of policy would have to change, alongside the policies implemented, for our vision of enhanced relationality (of enfranchised people working creatively together to find new meanings and changed human–world relations) to come to fruition.[2] It seems our best hope of getting that change in governance and leadership is through a groundswell that makes it inevitable.

Design Research in the Book

The collection shares examples of how people are practising careful and collaborative interventions across many different contexts: arts organisations, theatre groups, academic research and more. Practices come from across Europe (with influences and histories from a wider field) and address a range of orientations. This means the book is both a contribution to many types of practice, to be found scattered across disciplines and ways of working, and also a design research book, looking at the mechanisms that change cultural and behavioural norms.

In design research, unlike many other fields of study, the goal is to understand the process of making change, and sometimes also to enact it as part of learning, to look at the picture emerging. This is not to pinpoint phenomena, but to explore the dimensions of difference across which a phenomenon could or does occur. It is to investigate a rich variety of manifestations across possible contexts and use these expressions of difference to learn how to do our job as well as possible as designers contributing to or shaping this phenomenon. In design parlance, this is 'creating and expanding the design space where the solution … unfolds' for the designer (Gero & Milovanovic, 2022, p. 1). Through the process of juxtaposing examples, we create a design space in what is itself a form of design, assembling a book to present a single evolving stimulus promoting change.

Importantly, here, the creations assembled are the collective activities that might bring us closer to worlds that we would like to occupy. Our commitment, as a group of authors, is to change-making, mindful of located elements and the needs of life and living beings. The work, in being collective, builds solidarity, whether or not that is the primary goal. When we act in a group, for a reason, as part of a place or event, the specificities are what we notice and what guides us. It enables *these* people to hear *these* voices and influence *those* outcomes, strengthening the agency of both the group and its members; it supports us to feel our agency and our connection as well as exercise it (see also Chapter 14). There are no universally excellent mechanisms for this, though there are many mechanisms and many factors affecting them. For this reason, reflexivity is tantamount, both in grasping what our societies need and, in the moment, acting with each other. Designers, facilitators and participants who are alive to others, even as they are pushing action forward, ask: Who is participating? Who benefits? What stories are being told and whose are missing? What are we representing? How are we sensitising ourselves? We ask this of the beings in the circle and the ones who didn't get there, for whatever reason (such as the wolves in Chapter 12). What makes change effective in a place, with its unique mix of location, land, scale, culture and community? Which elements can travel elsewhere, and which don't – and why? How does relevance shift over time and what keeps a process fresh? It is important not to write out the difference that different disciplines, artistic traditions and ways of articulating the world contribute. It matters who is there on the day and how the invitation is worded. These details as well as the wider sweep of similarities

are the meat of this collection and the point of bringing different authors together. Our agency, as authors, must involve critical reflection and ethical sensitivity. And our willingness to learn (and develop as people and practitioners, designers and facilitators) is three-headed: an act of enjoyment, of supporting others and of prefiguring the change we want to see.

Practices for Whom?

When a practitioner aspires to transformation, however open-ended, there is a suggestion of making deliberate and deliberated change. This collection spans several disciplines as understood in contemporary arts scholarship with different orientations to practice. We have focused upon a point where they intersect, while seeking to avoid instrumentalising them as mere tools to an end. Instead, we are hoping that we give them room to breathe in these pages, celebrating their value but also their distinctiveness. Yet, by asking for whom they are intended, we draw on design's disciplinary traditions, for a design is made for something in particular and, often, for particular groups too, even if this may emerge in the making. Thus, as well as different styles of engagement, we can see a meeting point between the openness of art and the purposefulness of designing in the material here. It is possible to design to be open. It is possible to design to create an audience for work. It is possible to design to see what happens when particular structures, ideas, practices and people are brought in relation. (Design may be purposeful, but the purpose may be exploratory.) We may not always know for whom we are creating something at outset, though, as the chapters show, there are strong political as well as aesthetic motivations here.

Historically, theatre, performance and art had *audiences* and design had *users*. *Audience* and *user* are largely receptive categories, despite the cognitive (and other processing) work implied in each. The terms have been challenged by a succession of analysts from design to theatre (e.g., Bannon, 1991; White, 2013), interrogating the agency of those involved. Since then the nature of agency has come under further scrutiny, with greater thought to the meeting of human, man-made and other forces (e.g. Latour, 2007, 2014) and a recognition of agency as emergent (Barad, 2007), while new practices have made viewer-performer divisions less concrete. The arrival of video games and other digital forms of non-linear storytelling shook up relations definitively in all forms of art, much as photography changed visual art forever. Site-specific happenings, interactive art, "immersive" theatre and promenade work made a feature of their surroundings. For instance, dreamthinkspeak[3] took over London's newly empty Somerset House early in the 2000s (which was previously home to the Birth, Marriage and Death records for England and Wales) with *Don't Look Back,* an installation about death, involving actors presenting the Orpheus and Euridice legend. Punchdrunk[4] produces elaborate sets for its roving stories, allowing luck (and, as ambitions have grown, repeat visits) to spur individual audience members through distributed stories that culminate in a denouement that, ideally, everyone can find and witness.

Some theatre (such as documented in Chapters 4 and 9) became more game-like during this time, with outcomes led by participant choices. Instead of audience, these works had *players*. And how players were invited to participate became important. Unlike interaction in the immersive works above, where little is changed by talking to actors or other audients (though these exchanges are not ruled out), here, there are design questions such as whether players determine the ending of the engagement and how far? Are there two outcomes – win–lose, guilty–innocent, succeed–fail – or a series of possible outcomes or even an open space for audience-led determination? And who comes to play and to spectate in these hybrid encounters? White asks of theatrical form: 'what makes some kinds of audience participation seem trivial and embarrassing, and others substantial, seductive and effective?' (White, 2013, p. 1). In this, he poses an aesthetic question, but one concerned with the mechanics of engagement. The CreaTures Framework[5] encourages creative practitioners to dismantle the "black box" view of the arts popular with those frustrated by the failures of climate messaging. It observes a tendency to turn to the "magic" of art because of its effectiveness, but with no curiosity about processes by which engagement is achieved. The CreaTures' nine-dimension framework (Vervoort et al., 2024) offers vocabulary for articulating the often-invisible dynamics of this relating without reducing them to instrumental metrics, describing socially engaged art to promote changing Meanings (embodying, learning, imagining), changing Connections (caring, organising, inspiring) and changing Power (co-creating, empowering, subverting) – see also Chapters 2, 5, 6 and 14. CreaTures also commissioned a study into *Transforming Futures through Place-based Creative Practices* (Lawrence & Hall, 2022). We build on such reflections, looking past the seeming magic of delight and rapt attention to the means by which these effects are created and to which ends they are being put.

Immersion, Participation, Transformation

Effective techniques can be appropriated, not only for corporate-sponsored "green" events or depoliticised climate experiences, but to a variety of ends; the line between genuine engagement and instrumentalisation is thin. The processes we describe, while offering new places to look for societal relevance, take place in a context of political scepticism. On one side, there is scepticism that the arts are relevant when the dominant narrative is about the potential of technology. On the other, there is dismay that science understands art only as a communication medium for science messages and misses the relationship that culture has with the bones of a society. This scepticism is compounded when scientists and policymakers operationalise the arts for policy goals such as meeting governments' net zero pledges. Such aims rarely align with either the unpredictable, stochastic outcomes of participatory arts practice (which visibly resists A-to-B causal relations) or the systemic change envisioned in much transformation-oriented work (Feola, 2015). Requiring artists to be useful and relevant is already a symptom of

a culture fixated on accountability and measurement, which many in these pages resist – a culture that has diminished creative adaptability and, more broadly, supported an ethos with little respect for culture, habitats or life. In the chapters that follow, there is no single understanding of what change should be made, how, or any orthodoxy as to how we understand if it has manifested. Some chapters look at collective or collaborative transformation; some at inner processes that contribute to these shifts, including how the authors themselves are affected. This heterogeneity is important for it speaks to the subtleties of ethos and intention, producing complementary approaches that address everything from governance to inner worlds, justice to care, politics to joy. We weigh what we are bringing into the world: if a work is able to transform on the terms we set, what are we doing? We have some limited means of ensuring that the outcomes are not co-opted for the work of climate deniers and right-wing demagogues, that a particular agenda will remain relevant or regenerative of life. We have our mindfulness of these contexts and the way that life-affirming gestures move us towards kinship and a reminder of the colour, plurality and richness of the world. The authors here infuse the work with more than process; they ask for commitment and conscience.

Throughout our account so far, we have talked about participatory and immersive practices, both as a whittling down to what is relevant and as method. We make a distinction between *interaction*, which speaks of the exchange of inputs, and *participation*, which articulates a relation of *being involved*. We have used the term *immersive*, knowing it is a contentious choice, acknowledging and questioning its rise in popularity. As the term *immersive* becomes pervasive, contrasting with technology that is *virtual*, it is ever less clear which aspects of the body and mind are to be immersed and by which means. The construction of dedicated immersive event venues is one of the most obvious indications of just how big the sector has become (Barrett, 2025). For instance, Netflix's permanent physical spin-off, Netflix House[6] adds to this canon and complexity with physical immersion in shows that started as TV. We do not orientate to the term without misgivings.

Aligned with the values of the authors in this collection, the "post-immersive manifesto" coming out of theatre-making (Lopes Ramos et al., 2020) states:

> Post-Immersive participation should validate intimacy, tenderness, empathy and care over immersive spectacles.
>
> Post-Immersive participation emerges when the individual becomes a part of a temporary community.
>
> Post-Immersive participation needs to be a collective thinking event centred on what it is to be a human being living in late capitalist societies.
>
> *(p. 1)*

It is a critique of performance offering immersive worlds without the creative input of the people immersed in it. For instance, audiences might spend whole

evenings reading the painstaking correspondence to be found in a drawer in one of Punchdrunk's works, enjoying the attention to detail. (One visitor reported to have made 141 trips to explore different aspects of the Punchdrunk version of the ancient Greek–Trojan war while it was running in London, 2022–23,[7] pers. comm.) Yet, being immersed is not the same as being an active participant in the story.

Lopes Ramos and colleagues have a different type of event in their sights. They point to those *immersive experiences* that take a theme and merchandise it: where companies 'explicitly encourage consumption of food and alcohol as a way to participate in the world of the event' so that participation means spending on 'overpriced items in line with the evening's theme' (Lopes Ramos et al., 2020, p. 2). At time of writing, these shows, made memorable, differentiated and photogenic – in short, entertaining – by association with familiar film and fiction, are proliferating rapidly, offering audiences the chance to "live" a story they already know. London has recently seen shows with names like *The Great Gatsby Immersive Experience, Charles Dickens at Christmas, Mamma Mia! the Party*, etc. While these might appropriately claim to be *immersive* in terms of stimulating multiple senses and embedding people – often in costume – into the entertainment, the offer of brand partnerships, "VIP packages" and "corporate" experiences makes clear how easily immersion can be folded into the individualising, financialising and extractive logics that Lopes Ramos and team set themselves against.

Yet, merely repudiating the design, quality and/or politics of immersion is also insufficient. If we take a (post)phenomenological perspective on the practices we are describing, then we – humans and other species – are always fully immersed in our worlds; there is, strictly speaking, no such thing as a *non*-immersive experience. This begs further caveats: just as a particular episode can be distinguished – however loosely – from the constant flow of experience of our waking hours (see Dewey, 1958), we might also recognise a form of immersion that is bounded, intentional and crafted. It has a beginning and an end; it can be prepared for and reflected upon afterwards. Experience can become narrative, with a start and finish, and immersion can be designed, framed with onboarding and post-immersion reflection. There can be invitations, crafted to collect particular groupings, mindful of how best they can be reached and supported. There can be hosting, to create a welcome and way into a safe-enough space. The immersion can be liminal, in taking people outside their usual worlds and then back, to a transformed everyday, in the tripartite structure of *rites of passage* (Van Gennep, 1960), or liminoid (Turner, 1974), in taking them out of their usual worlds and losing sight of them, thereby leaving the experience to become mere sensation (sensation in being felt and being arresting, but no more). The authors in this collection have all come to see the value of a reflective stage post-transportation so that learning from the journey can be integrated into more ordinary life to become meaningful.

In the sense we use *immersive* in this collection, it is a deliberate step into an alternative universe that heightens or reconfigures the senses, asking participants

to set aside the every day to attend to the world unfolding around them and return with their affective and reflexive faculties sharpened. In such moments, the altered state is not simply a temporary departure from the ordinary – it is an *altering state*, in which the conditions of perception and relation shift and from which one returns changed. It is in this *altering* that the group may participate, as much as in the activities being offered.

Here, Bishop's (Bishop, 2012) oft-cited argument that participatory art is a neoliberal phenomenon – a way for the ruling classes to hold onto power while handing over a sense of agency to the rest of society – raises a key concern. Yet, when people act together, participation becomes more than expression or consultation; it becomes a way of generating influence. Shared concerns, voiced and worked through collectively, gain legitimacy and force, pressing against existing arrangements. In this sense, participatory practice itself becomes political. Research on collective behaviour shows that even loosely formed groups can have a powerful effect on how people think, feel and act. Group membership is not just a descriptive category but a shared point of orientation, shaping how situations are understood and what kinds of action seem possible. Through participatory practice, people often begin to take collective concerns personally: what matters for the group comes to matter for the individual. Belonging can provide meaning, purpose and a framework for interpreting social reality (Tajfel & Turner, 1979), and participation is one of the main ways this alignment is formed.

These shifts have practical consequences. Psychological research demonstrates that identifying with a group is associated with greater willingness to engage in coordinated action, from everyday cooperation to sustained political mobilisation (e.g., van Zomeren et al., 2008). When people come to see their own outcomes as bound with those of others, collective action becomes not only a way to address shared concerns, but a means of affirming who they are in relation to others. Participatory practice operates through its emotional and relational qualities: experiences of solidarity, intimacy, shared pride or moral obligation can embolden people to act in ways they might not attempt alone. Studies of social movements repeatedly show that participants describe their involvement as personally transformative: through acting with others, they discover new capacities, commitments and senses of agency (Drury & Reicher, 2005). From this perspective, participatory practices do not simply mobilise people towards change that lies elsewhere. They are sites in which change is rehearsed, felt and made present. By reshaping how people relate to one another, to shared concerns, and to their own capacity to act, participation can bring aspects of social transformation into being in the here and now.

Thus, participatory structures are as much a form to be designed as anything else. When approached with an alternative politics, they may be a space in which to choreograph encounters where meaning is co-felt and co-constructed (rather than "delivered"), and where success lies in the capacity to offer alternative relations and a call to perpetuate them, not simply entertainment or patronage. As the

Boomtown team (Chapter 10) say: 'fun is not a distraction from the ideas being explored, but the very thing that makes participation possible, opening the door to play, experimentation and collective imagination'. Furthermore, the examples we bring together here start from a position that communities and social networks pre-exist us and attend to their own concerns, most of the time without design support: 'the very concept of participation presupposes there is something going on beyond you to which you can be invited… Looked at another way, they may just be doing something else with a different centre of attention and their own priorities' (Light, 2018, p. 151). Staging something, we invite people to join in activities that relate to our interests and, in so doing, look for an intersection with their interests, defining the participants who will respond to our invitation, style of facilitation and particular mode of practice.

Consequently, what is meant by participation – and who participates – is different in every chapter in this book, and authors make a point of explaining what is involved, how and where. In some chapters, we hear from designers and, in fewer, from participants. We explore immersive performance, larp (live action role-play), interactive storytelling, participatory workshops, city-building festivals and social practice art. Each offers a slightly different grammar of engagement under a commitment to involve people in co-created, affect-rich, embodied potential. But, in each chapter, the play of agency between makers and participants is not a foregone conclusion and there is room – and even encouragement – for upsets in the balance of power (as Chapter 8 touches on). This is a different politics to the one that inspires Bishop (2012) to comment that socially engaged participatory art is supported to: 'enable all members of society to be self-administering, fully functioning consumers who do not rely on the welfare state and who can cope with a deregulated, privatised world' (p. 14). In her view, this art becomes indistinguishable from government policy, and it is true that the expectation (and nurturing) of self-reliance has only become starker since Bishop wrote those words (see Chapters 3 and 13 for discussion of resilience from different perspectives). But we argue that there are politics running orthogonal to this view of relations.

The Politics

Immersive, affective practices engage the whole person – in tandem with cognition – activating emotions, senses, bodies and social relations. Jasanoff comments on how climate *facts* arise from impersonal observation, whereas *meanings* emerge from embedded experience (2010). Thus, employing climate science as the main means of communication cuts against the grain of common sense and undermines existing social institutions and ethical commitments (2010). This collection takes seriously the need to work with/through embedded experience and employ common sense in its fullest terms. It is from this that a different politics derives. Beyond an interest in immersion and participation, what unites our writings is a performative orientation – not only in the theatrical sense, but in a

broader philosophical one. A performative orientation treats the world as dynamic and enacted, brought into being by the doing of it (see, for instance, Butler, 2006). Change is a lived process, one that is staged, improvised and felt. It has no endpoint or natural state. This collection asks for an emancipatory co-creative practice that rehearses and makes worlds and resists inflexible futures, finding both existence and expression in the acting out in place.

In this politics, we reject ideas of *prediction* and *assessment,* invoking the gentler mood of *anticipation* and *recognition* and decrying a system that stresses measurement at the expense of care. As the post-immersive manifesto says, we can and should be operating with values of 'intimacy, tenderness, empathy and care', not 'spectacle' (Lopes Ramos et al., 2020, p. 1) and not (merely) efficiency. By embracing care, these practices offer more than a critique of the present – they give a taste of the possible. Participants might spend an afternoon as policymakers navigating choices, as election agents promoting an AI candidate, or as wolves exploring human-impacted landscapes. In these scenarios, understanding emerges not from abstraction but through embodied experience, dialogue and reflection. It is worlding, not political abstraction.

So, we would argue, the politics of the work here should not be judged as another manifestation of neoliberalism, as some might be. It is precisely against this backdrop that the collected work stakes out different politics and a different way of conceiving the political. Here, immersion is not a commodity to be consumed but a space of relation-building, where the performative becomes a basis for politics rooted in fluidity, in the pluriversal and in more-than-human inclusion. Following Rancière's notion of the 'partition of the sensible' (Rancière, 2004), these practices can be understood as aesthetic acts that reconfigure who and what becomes perceptible in public life – bringing all lifeforms and future generations, as well as conditions of marginalisation and oppression, onto the stage of collective concern. In this sense, the politics of participation lies less in consensus-building or structuring than in making new relations and possibilities feel thinkable – a possitopian position (McKenzie, n.d.) of increasing and exploring options. Seen through the lens of relational aesthetics, immersive spaces can act as micro-utopias: temporary re-distributions of roles, materials and affects that let participants sense what other worlds might feel like.

This work is both imaginative and pragmatic. It aligns with Cairns' review of enabling collective imagining beyond crisis, which finds a "re-membering" of humans in broader kinship with the animate earth; challenges to temporalities of crisis; the honouring of emotions such as joy, hope and grief; and the reconnection with somatic wisdom and ritual (2025). Such work does not dictate specific outcomes, but invites exploration, improvisation and mutual discovery. And it does so with a focus on agency, not as control, but as emergent, collective capacity. It is part of movements where boundaries are regularly questioned to prevent exclusion, where histories of colonialism and appropriation are acknowledged along with celebration of creating, connecting and being joyful and where love

of making does not deplete resources and helps dismantle the unsustainability of dominant human societies. This work seeks to bring humans' best selves to the fore, recognising the mutability of our species and our strength as custodians of other creatures, land and place, without necessarily an agenda about what happens next. In this, it is a form of prefigurative politics – being the change in the making of it.

Affective Prefiguration

Much of the work we are describing manifests what we are calling *affective prefiguration*: designing and staging encounters that allow people to inhabit a relational future they wish to build and can take inspiration from (Light, 2023; Light & Millen, 2026). *Affective prefiguration* was coined to talk about relatings that do not extensively exist in the present but can be hinted at or sampled through the design of encounter. This might be a space where the pressures of capitalistic hegemony and valorisation of the individual over the collective are absent for the duration of the encounter. 'To effect urgent change, we require different capacities for feeling as well as different feelings. Affective prefiguration means giving experience in the present of what else might be emotionally and relationally possible' (Light, 2023, p. 24). Adding this extra dimension to contemporary life might invoke a *constitutive anthropology* (Light, 2015): using participatory work as "staged encounters" to align people differently and learn what is possible for them to be when conditions support a changed way of being – to find out what humans together become with the right stimuli (2015). This has echoes in other design work, considering 'how contextualised and relational practices are materialised and co-produced among partners that try out and take on different roles and responsibilities' (Brandt & Foverskov, 2024, p. 99). It also acknowledges that not everyone has lost age-old relations of kinship, but that, even where these survive, they are struggling against dominant ideologies of self/world divide and acquisition (e.g., Ford et al., 2020).

Fians (2022) describes prefigurative politics as: 'strategies and practices employed by political activists to build alternative futures in the present and to effect political change by not reproducing the social structures' they oppose (n.p.). This stresses progressive organisational structures – new economies, different legal systems, replacements for policing and so on – designed to contrast with mainstream processes, feed into social practice (Papadopoulos, 2018) and create what Cooper (2014) calls "everyday utopias". DiSalvo has explained prefigurative design as an 'approach to produce prototypes of artefacts, systems and environments through which we could experience possible politics conditions' (DiSalvo, 2016, p. 34). *Affective prefiguration* gives primacy to evolving relations rather than the structures that might emerge. Clarke and Drury observe what they call 'emergent prefiguration' (Clarke & Drury, 2025) in protest situations where people come to recognise they are creating what they want in their futures. We

see a connection to this here, where trying out a feeling is key to developing a desire and impetus for it, but note that opportunities for this may be intentionally designed into the contexts we share. Calling for deeper analysis of the 'politics of the act' (2026), Vestergren and colleagues acknowledge the vital role of spontaneous experimentation, the breadth of constitutive emotions (such as awe, hope and joy) and the importance of considering radical imagination and temporality as inherent properties of political struggle. Designing conditions for participative intimacy (Light et al., 2024; Light & Millen, 2026), practitioners can invite people into welcome situations where forms of kinship relating – human and more-than-human – can be tested, rehearsed and sometimes made real.

Exploring the Design Space

The examples in the book bring together recognisable common mechanisms, such as creating liminal spaces, inviting playful engagement and relying on participant contribution, while revealing striking differences. They exist across diverse contexts, as reported. However, even when the context is ostensibly the same, the interpretation can vary significantly in the performing of it. We briefly use the idea of a *spa* to illustrate how intentions, structures and impacts can differ in different artists' hands.

Spas, linked to rest, comfort and care, historically a place of special waters and often a playground for the rich, share liminal features with other "experiences" in asking visitors to step out of their ordinary day. Cassie Thornton's *Social Spa for Collective Mutation* in Switzerland invites visitors to reflect on privilege, responsibility and change by breaking plates; Rebecca Fraser's *Future Spa* in Scotland creates a gentle, sensory space where people can relax, share stories and imagine local futures together; and Ruth Catlow's *Interspecies Daycare and Spa* in London turns a park into a playful setting for exploring interspecies relations.

Artist and debt activist Thornton's iconoclastic *Social Spa for Collective Mutation* took place in a progressive spa in the Swiss town of Basel. Touted as a space 'you can come to when you know you need to change but you're not sure how' (Thornton, 2024, n.p.), she taunted visitors to use their bodies to heat the spa water made cold by quantities of Swiss francs. People were invited into the baths to the *Global Stress Smash Therapy Room* to consider how they live 'in the deep belly of fortress Europe' (2024), writing personal habits they want to break on a plate and then smashing it in front of others. At the end of the project, there was a full bath of smashed plates with people's intentions on them. Participating and immersed, visitors nonetheless experienced much of the drama in the contrast between the spa's normal culture and the ideas that Thornton brought.

Easterhouse, a Glasgow inner suburb, needs love, not shock. Much of it ranks in the top 5% of deprived areas of Scotland (SIMD, 2020). Fraser, an artist working as part of the Climate Ready Clyde project,[8] chose to use the idea of a spa – not an actual spa with pools or treatments, but a conceptual setting – to support

Easterhouse communities to imagine futures for the neighbourhood. 'Relaxing sensory activities were at the root of my "Future Spa" workshops because I wanted participants to feel they had the emotional margin to connect with ideas about the future and the environment' (Culture for Climate Scotland, 2024, n.p.). Where Thornton stressed privilege, Fraser dwelt on a spa's restful and therapeutic aspects, working with local residents to release the thoughts that letting go of usual considerations might yield. The legacy from these workshops is a comfortable chair in a public space and a soundtrack capturing inspiration that came to participants engaging in sensory exercises. Passers-by are invited to 'pause, rest, listen and imagine your future' (CCF Easterhouse, 2024, n.p.). If Thornton was subversive in undermining Swiss comfort, Fraser was subversive in opening this spot for luxuriating.

The spa appears too in work by Furtherfield and its director Catlow, whose role-play as part of *The Treaty of Finsbury Park* (Furtherfield, 2025; Light et al., 2024; Chapter 2) involved an afternoon's play in a London park. This agenda was also political. Catlow cites 'our sense of human exceptionalism and how that then unfolds for all kinds of colonial power structures, how infrastructures are made, how management structures, all organised to dominate life forms, to see life as a resource, as a series of assets' (Accidental Gods, 2023, n.p.). Again, no physical spa materialised, but humans-as-plants-and-other-animals, wearing masks to represent their species, were treated to a meditation under the trees as a means to 'get into their new bodies' (Accidental Gods, 2023, n.p.) and consider how habitat might be respected better. This helped reveal the ways in which different species improve each other's lives: 'the tree providing shelter to the squirrels and the insects over generations and, then, into their post-life, care for things like the stag beetle. Together, you gain a very strong shared understanding of everything we're not attending to all the time' (Accidental Gods, 2023, n.p.). Relaxing in an "interspecies spa" here gave time to consider both the environment of the park and characteristics of a kin species.

Looking at the three, the familiar idea of *the spa* and its trappings, such as privilege, is a canvas and a contrast, used to shake things up in the first two examples (especially in terms of class and access), and acting as a sufficiently recognisable frame for Catlow to project new relations into the group of masked participants. It is shaped for local conditions, the artist's ambitions and physical surroundings. The three pieces, brought together, show the range of possible immersive interventions we might include in this book. Each transforms a familiar setting to invite types of experience – one challenging, one calming, one imaginative. They are worlds apart in their ambitions, incidentally picking the same framing.

Yet, each of the three invites critique, more or less gently, of current norms and "normal" life. Further, they offer playfulness, expecting that some of the creative work will be undertaken by participants and drawing people into a state where collaboration with strangers is more likely to occur. The pieces do not really exist outside this encounter, as a spa-mounted manifesto could. The organisers make

themselves vulnerable to the non-participation of participants needed to bring the work to life. In this respect, they are similar, conceived to be animated by others.

Last, they are examples that can help raise questions about what counts as immersive or participatory. Compared to some of the more intense practices in this book, the first two, in particular, feel lighter and more reflective. They highlight how hard it is to pin down exactly what these practices are and what they might mean for particular individuals and groups. For this reason alone, it is important to keep space for many different approaches.

The Rest of this Volume

This book is neither a theory-led treatise nor a how-to manual. It sits somewhere between, as a collection of reflective, situated accounts from those working at an intersection that brings together art, performance, design research, theatre studies, games and larp studies, anthropology and environmental humanities, concerned with eco-social transformation. The chapters share a commitment to immersive, participatory and, often explicitly, eco-social practice, but what became clear through the editorial process is that no single theme or vocabulary runs cleanly across them all. Rather, each contribution brushes up against others in partial ways. Our task has therefore not been to extract a unifying narrative, but to work with this plurality and invite readers to attend to how different practices speak to one another.

The journey begins in Chapter 2 'Learning by Imagining: Teacher-in-Role to Edu-Larps', where Ann Light traces a personal and pedagogical lineage from role-based teaching to educational larping. Drawing on her own work over multiple decades, she illustrates the learning environments that preceded some of the current initiatives, both within and outside formal education, to use immersive co-created techniques for transformative ends. This sets the tone for the collection by grounding immersive practice in an ethos of change through collective reflection; opening the question of how, concretely, such practices come to effect change in individuals and groups; and asking whether different traditions can learn from each other.

Picking up the question of how transformation takes place, Chapter 3 'From Opposition to Transformation: Building Resilience with Pretensive Methodologies' by Mátyás Hartyándi turns towards more general applied drama and maps out three different orientations to resilience – opposition, adaptation and transformation. Situating a rich mix of methods, from gaming simulations through educational role-play to sociodrama, Hartyándi explores how each approach encourages different forms of collective agency, offering a more explicitly conceptual lens on the kinds of shifts that Chapter 2 begins to narrate in practice.

Extending this analysis of impact of different forms of participation, Chapter 4 'Rehearsing Relations: Imagining Alternative Futures as Artistic Practice' by Zoë Svendsen takes the discussion to participatory theatre, making the case for

speculative practices as critical tools for social transformation. Through the project 'Imagining Otherwise', she and her collaborators explore climate dramaturgy, not as didactic instruction, but as a rehearsal for co-imagining liveable futures – demonstrating how stepping into fictional futures can challenge present assumptions and open space for alternative ways of organising life.

Building on this argument for imaginative experimentation, Chapter 5 'Between Knowing and Acting: A Dialectic Exchange with Anab Jain and Jon Ardern of Superflux' turns to a different tradition of future-making as the Superflux co-founders discuss their speculative design practice. Rather than mapping futures from a distance, they reflect on the tensions, uncertainties and creative risks involved in crafting worlds that provoke new orientations to the possible – emphasising the importance of designing experiences that resonate emotionally as well as intellectually.

Chapter 6 'Unlocking the Resonant Power of Video Games to Mobilize Cultural Change' takes this concern with resonance into the digital sphere and shifts the focus to gaming. Joost Vervoort examines the largely untapped potential of video games as sites for engaging with systemic change, considering how world-building, affective immersion and player agency can foster powerful imaginative identification. Reflecting on the disconnect between transformation theorists and game developers, he proposes strategies for bridging these worlds so that games might meaningfully connect with – and move – their audiences at scale. He uses the *All Will Rise* game as an example of how to maintain playful values while carrying serious climate dilemmas.

Staying within the realm of play but shifting form, Chapter 7, 'Being Mrs Rochester: Empathy in Live Action Role-Playing' offers Nordic larp as a tool for fostering empathy, through the eyes of scholars Sara Bjärstorp and Petra Ragnerstam. As participants in a week-long evocation of Jane Austen's world in Sweden, they examine how carefully designed immersive environments allow players to explore unfamiliar relationalities and encounter discomfort in a managed way. Here, too, games function as a mode of engaging with transformation – this time through embodied role-taking and the emotional stretch of inhabiting other worlds and lives. Their analysis of inter- and intra-personal empathy reveals a subtle form of reflexive learning.

Continuing this close attention to the relational aspects of design work, Chapter 8 'Design Encounters: Inviting Speculation in the Here-and-Now' by Thomas Binder and Eva Brandt positions participatory design as a speculative rehearsal in the city. They argue that designing is itself a form of staging – of crafting encounters with the not-yet and enabling people to practise new social relations in the present. In this way, the chapter extends the focus on how specific configurations of interaction and attention make alternative ways of being together momentarily real in the every day.

The emphasis on situated civic relations shifts into a more explicitly policy-related arena in Chapter 9 'The Strategy Room: Using Interactive Performance to

Create Democratic Design', where Daniel Barnard takes speculative rehearsal into a discussion of decision-making, influence and agency. Drawing on interactive theatre, action-based storytelling and digital interfaces, Barnard describes how local residents are brought together to deliberate on concrete climate policies possible in their own places. Through "postcards from the future", facilitated discussion and structured voting, participants do not merely imagine alternative futures but consider how different policy designs might play out in everyday life to inform local authority actions.

Chapter 10 'Boomtown: World Building as Experiential Design' extends this exploration of civic participation into a more playful register through a reflection by Boomtown's Mair Morel and Megan Clifton with James Wheale. Framed as the largest interactive theatre in the world, Boomtown operates as a temporary city with its own districts, storylines and social dynamics. Here, democratic mechanisms are woven into the fabric of the experience: participants navigate evolving narratives and environmental politics within the festival itself, sampling alternative civic structures and collective futures at festival scale – a reminder that civic imagination can be both festive and transformative.

Chapter 11 'Collective and Urgent: Sociodrama as a Holding Space for Climate Activism' carries forward this exploration of participatory improvised space, shifting it from festival-scale play into the terrain of climate breakdown experienced across worlds. This chapter follows a real-time online sociodrama in which climate activists and creative practitioners confront catastrophe as it is unfolding. Valerie Monti Holland documents how immersive role-play, role-reversal and collective storytelling become tools for processing fear, grief and powerlessness while also generating insight, solidarity and action. In this setting, spontaneity is not entertainment but a survival skill: a way for groups to adapt, imagine and respond together and maintain care.

Chapter 12 'Crafty Practices of Masking: Stories from Beyond Duality' continues this focus on responding creatively to real-world pressures, but shifts from activism to multispecies coexistence. Elisabeth Tauber, Seçil Uğur Yavuz and Lisa Maria Zellner describe a workshop that opens space for crafting masks to enable dialogue between humans and wolves – a practice developed in the context of ongoing ecological tensions. Through merging artful practices, multispecies ethnography and speculative storytelling, interlocutors are invited to craft and shift perspectives, moving beyond conflict or fear and intuiting new possibilities for thriving together.

Chapter 13 'Building Readiness with Time Travel: Relevance and Scale in Adapting a "Here-and-Then" Futures Workshop' returns to the larp form, but now in a way that subtly gathers together the volume's central concerns – from imagining alternative futures through play, to nurturing civic agency and attending to more-than-human relations. Ann Light and Ruth Catlow describe *This Coastal Town*, a readiness workshop set in a small coastal community in the near and more remote future, where participants inhabit heightened versions of themselves

to explore how rising seas and shifting interdependencies might reshape everyday life. By rooting speculation in familiar places and relationships, the work invites people to face unsettling futures collectively and supportively, strengthening awareness of relations and local agency. The chapter considers what it takes to make the workshop transferable to other places and to work with communities of interest.

The final substantive chapter, Chapter 14, 'Evaluation as Participatory Design Practice: Extending and Capturing Impact' by Astrid Breel, looks at participation, agency and impact. Considering the case of Coney's interactive theatre, she sets out the value and potential of embedding evaluative thinking across the timeframe of a project and introduces the concept of *Emergent Value* as a way of thinking about participant-centred and embedded approaches to evaluation that might use the aesthetic language of a piece to offer a meaningful moment of reflection for participants.

The volume closes with 'A Coda on Flourishing Futures: Into the Trees', reflecting on what is left unanswered by the material and where else we might look for inspiration to build integrity and care for all life into the design of engagements.

And All the Rest...

It is tempting to attempt an exhaustive account of the intersections we are discussing, at least as undertaken in similar (post)industrial milieus. But we can only address some tiny fraction of the creative work that is being used to engage, challenge and move others. In exploring the limits of what this book covers, we omitted a host of practices and techniques, despite our interest in range and variety. For instance, there are *embedded artists' schemes* that are designed to show the value of the arts to transformation, but which concern the institutional value of involving creative practice and less specifically the types of approach (e.g., Cultural Adaptations[9]). Instead, a focus on the *experiential* and *co-constituted* has been our guide, limiting our field to how the collaborative work of embodied imagining and speculating makes a difference.

In reflecting on the settings of our included material, there is little in the wilds and much in built and online spaces, despite an interest in relating more broadly. Even the work with naturalists and farmers (Chapter 12) is indoors, the parks mentioned are surrounded by city life, and the orchards in the coda are part of the village. There is, of course, inspiring immersive work specifically taking people out of these contexts to encourage attention to land and life (e.g., the participatory wing of European Landart Network,[10] such as Land Art i Skåne[11]). Immersion in the liveness of the world can create new meanings and we note the work of practitioners taking people to experience a different type of connection through rites of passage (e.g., Israh Goodall[12]); pathways for awakening mind and body to the more-than-human world to reveal innate interconnection (e.g., Connection 1st[13]) and other forms of orienting through land,[14] endeavouring to be 'good company

for those finding their way–and leading others–across perilous thresholds in liminal times' (Wolf Willow, n.d., n.p.). Krater,[15] in Ljubljana, acts as the situated prototype of a terraforming agency, offering open access, ever-evolving workshop spaces in dialogue with the impoverished crust of earth in their feral central city location. Theirs is just one of many inspiring green space projects that blend growing, mending and healing, regenerating human–world relations by bringing life into cities, rather than taking people out of them.

There is also practice devoted to awakening attention to Indigenous lifeworlds, other forms of living and the beauty of other lives, where most emphasis is upon clever use of the outcome of the creative process. One example is the South African theatre of Empatheatre, embedded in citizen assemblies bringing together those implicated. The Empatheatre animation *Indlela Yokuphila*[16] has been used in policymaking and to fight court cases. There are immersive interactive experiences that transform orientation to other living beings one person at a time, such as *The Living Coast Undersea Experience*[17] by KP Projects, where virtual reality (VR) offers the local marine environment for people to move through, to exit surrounded by sea-related educational materials. 2016's *Collisions,*[18] by Lynette Wallworth, used 360° VR to offer the perspective of elder Nyarri Nyarri Morgan's first encounter with British atomic tests on the land now known as Australia. It was shown worldwide, raised awareness of Indigenous experiences with nuclear testing and influenced UN policy on banning tests. But these are not the focus of this book. While people may be immersed fully, most people who encounter these experiences are meeting the art ready-made, well framed by a process that makes it powerful. By contrast, the emphasis of the work in the following pages is on bringing together constellations that, however temporarily, become a community in the creation of alternatives; artefacts might prompt us, but the *imagining together* is incorporated in the event and influential as part of finding the eco-social.[19] Furthermore, so far, these collective acts of bonding through creation and creation through bonding seem impervious to the predations of Artificial Intelligence.

Of course, there is more participatory process work than we could ever have included. For instance, Finnish artist duo *Suomi/Koivisto,* working in Spain, have created a collective dreaming ritual that involves sleeping overnight in a drought-resistant garden;[20] *Sisters Hope* in Denmark welcome groups to inhabit space in silence for days at a time, stressing what is sensuous in the world around them to build a sensuous society;[21] the UK's *Blast Theory* use participatory game-like structures for political ends,[22] while *Town Anywhere* invites locals to build the futures of their area.[23] In the USA, *Burning Man* attendees have been living in prefigurative relations for about 40 years.[24] And the walking work initiated by artist Barbara Keal as a pilgrimage from the English south coast to the COP26 meeting[25] in Scotland, with the *Coat of Hopes*,[26] is participatory and immersive in a number of ways: it is possible to walk with the coat; wear it and/or make patches for it, capturing something on embroidered sections of blanket that is personally significant (Figure 1.1). It is also possible to invite it to your neighbourhood, thereby changing

its route, as it meanders round the UK inspiring people to consider ecological breakdown and the responsibilities we share, long after its original purpose of walking to Glasgow in 2021 was fulfilled.

In some cases, we can celebrate the detailed scrutiny that people have already given to their own workings, meaning that this book exists in adjacency to theirs. *Playing for Time: Making Art as if the World Mattered* (2015) by Lucy Neal, with many other artists, is an extraordinary work that must be mentioned in linking art and climate activism. We are also thinking of the fashion fictions of Amy Twigger Holroyd (2025), which unpick the destructive world of fast fashion in participatory speculative world-making; the EDGE[27] programme's work on *Transformative Game Design* (Bowman et al., 2025), or the anticipated *Speculative Game Design* (Flanagan & Carney, forthcoming), among others.

In picking what we brought together here, we have leant towards practices that evoke alternatives and analysis that helps us understand the workings of these



FIGURE 1.1 Barbara Keal and the Coat of Hopes, in the southern English town of Lewes, 2026. Next stop, the Isle of Wight.

Credit: Ann Light, with permission.

evocations, taking forward Light's interest in collaborative speculation to consider the mechanics that help democratise futures (Light, 2021). Working through immersive arts and participatory design involves considerable labour, much of which is invisible. It doesn't provide neat solutions to ongoing predicaments or impacts that are easily classified. These approaches will not resolve ecological breakdown or restore fractured societies on their own. But they do offer something crucial: a space to rehearse change; to feel one's way into difference; and to build collective muscle for alternative ways of being, whether in the heart or in the structures of society. These playful encounters, grounded in careful design, are part of a wider cultural project – one that is emergent, experimental and urgently needed.

Notes

1 We, the editors and authors here, recognise our good fortune and opportunity in having jobs we love, while remaining affected by the same colonial systems that structure servitude and time-poverty.
2 A hint of what governance could look like can be found in an earlier piece of work for the UK's NESTA innovation foundation, included as the first entry here: https://media.nesta.org.uk/documents/Radical_Visions_of_Future_Government_-_final.pdf
3 dreamthinkspeak: https://dreamthinkspeak.com/
4 Punchdrunk: https://www.punchdrunk.com/
5 *CreaTures Framework*. https://creaturesframework.org/
6 Netflix House: https://www.netflix.com/tudum/articles/netflix-house
7 Punchdrunk's *The Burnt City:* https://www.punchdrunk.com/work/the-burnt-city/
8 Climate Ready Clyde was building on Creative Carbon Scotland's Embedded Artist Scheme, which puts artists into non-arts institutions to galvanise change (see https://cultureforclimate.scot/services/arts-into-climate/). Creative Carbon Scotland became Culture for Climate Scotland in 2025.
9 Cultural Adaptations: https://www.culturaladaptations.com/toolkit/embedded-artist-projects-for-adaptation-toolkit/
10 European Landart Network: http://www.landart-network.eu/
11 Land Art i Skåne: https://landart.eileenlaurie.se/
12 Israh Goodall: https://www.israhgoodall.com
13 Connection 1st: https://www.livingconnection1st.net/
14 E.g., The Real Farming Trust's 'Listening to the Land Day': https://realfarming.org/event/listening-to-the-land-day-2026/
15 Krater, Slovenia (in English): https://krater.si/en
16 Empatheatre: https://www.empatheatre.com/IndlelaYokuphila
17 KP Projects: https://www.kp-projects.co.uk/the-living-coast-undersea-experience/
18 Lynette Wallworth: https://lynettewallworth.com/works/collisions
19 Well framed artworks may become participatory and this distinction blurs (Light 2021).
20 Suomi/Koivisto Architects: https://www.suomikoivisto.fi/thirdoflife
21 Sisters Hope: https://sistershope.dk/
22 Blast Theory's *Operation Black Antler* invited people to infiltrate staged gatherings of sects to spy: https://www.blasttheory.co.uk/projects/operation-black-antler/
23 This account of *Town Anywhere-Tooting* takes the process to the immediate environment of one of the co-founders, Lucy Neal: https://www.transitiontooting.org/2024/10/town-anywhere-tooting-2.html
24 The Burning Man Project: https://burningman.org/about-us/10-principles/

25 Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). Further arts work at Glasgow, which was a particularly good showcase for protest creativity can be found in the report by Creative Carbon Scotland, as was, at https://zenodo.org/records/7545141
26 Coat of Hopes: https://www.coatofhopes.uk/
27 Empowering Game Design Education with Transformative Role-playing Games (EDGE) – An Erasmus+ Cooperation Partnership in Higher Education.

References

Abdulla, D. (2025). *Design otherwise*. Bloomsbury Publishing. https://www.bloomsbury.com/uk/design-otherwise-9781350295773/

Accidental Gods. (2023, July 10). Becoming a stag beetle! Living the interspecies treaty of Finsbury Park with Ruth Catlow. *Accidental Gods*. https://accidentalgods.life/becoming-a-stag-beetle-living-the-interspecies-treaty-of-finsbury-park-with-ruth-catlow/

Bannon, L. J. (1991). From human factors to human actors: The role of psychology and human-computer interaction studies in system design. In J. Greenbaum & M. Kyng (Eds.), *Design at work*. CRC Press.

Barad, K. (2007). *Meeting the universe halfway: Quantum physics and the entanglement of matter and meaning.* Duke University Press Books.

Barrett, C. (2025). World's apart: The evolution of immersive events. *Access All Areas*. Retrieved June 10, 2025, from https://accessaa.co.uk/worlds-apart-the-evolution-of-immersive-events/

Bishop, C. (2012). *Artificial hells: Participatory art and the politics of spectatorship.* Verso Books.

Bowman, S. L., Diakolambrianou, E., & Brind, S. (Eds). (2025). *Transformative role-playing game design*. Uppsala University Publications. https://doi.org/10.33063/23xd2197

Braidotti, R. (2010). The posthuman predicament. In A. Smelik (Ed.), *The scientific imaginary in visual culture* (pp. 69–88). V&R Unipress. https://doi.org/10.14220/9783862347568.69

Brandt, E., & Foverskov, M. (2024). Rehearsing and performing in design and living labs: Situated, relational and embodied participatory design roles in partnerships. *Proceedings of the Participatory Design Conference 2024: Full Papers, 1*(1), 98–111. https://doi.org/10.1145/3666094.3666105

Brown, A. (2014). *Art & ecology now.* Thames and Hudson Ltd.

Butler, J. (2006). *Gender trouble: Feminism and the subversion of identity.* Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203824979

Cairns, R. (2025). Cultivating collective imagination beyond crisis. *Environmental Science & Policy*, *169*, 104074. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.envsci.2025.104074

CCF Easterhouse. (2024). *Future spa*. CCF Easterhouse. https://www.ccfeasterhouse.com/future-spa

Clarke, D., & Drury, J. (2025). Emergent prefigurative politics and social psychological processes: A systematic review and research agenda. *Journal of Community & Applied Social Psychology*, *35*(1), e70040. https://doi.org/10.1002/casp.70040

Cooper, D. (2014). *Everyday Utopias: The conceptual life of promising spaces*. Duke University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv1220qrp

Culture for Climate Scotland. (2024). *The story of imagining climate-ready futures—Culture for climate Scotland*. https://cultureforclimate.scot/the-story-of-imagining-climate-ready-futures/

Dewey, J. (1958). *Art as experience*. Capricorn Books.

DiSalvo, C. (2016). Design and prefigurative politics. *The Journal of Design Strategies*, *8*(1), 29–35.

Drury, J., & Reicher, S. (2005). Explaining enduring empowerment: A comparative study of collective action and psychological outcomes. *European Journal of Social Psychology*, *35*(1), 35–58. https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.231

Escobar, A. (2018). *Designs for the pluriverse: Radical interdependence, autonomy and the making of worlds*. Duke University Press. https://doi.org/10.1215/9780822371816

Fedele, G., Donatti, C. I., Harvey, C. A., Hannah, L., & Hole, D. G. (2019). Transformative adaptation to climate change for sustainable social-ecological systems. *Environmental Science & Policy*, *101*, 116–125. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.envsci.2019.07.001

Feola, G. (2015). Societal transformation in response to global environmental change: A review of emerging concepts. *Ambio*, *44*(5), 376–390. https://doi.org/10.1007/s13280-014-0582-z

Fians, G. (2022). Prefigurative politics. *The Open Encyclopedia of Anthropology*. https://doi.org/10.29164/22prefigpolitics

Flanagan, M., & Carney, L. (forthcoming). *Speculative game design*. (Original work published MIT Press)

Ford, J. D., King, N., Galappaththi, E. K., Pearce, T., McDowell, G., & Harper, S. L. (2020). The resilience of Indigenous peoples to environmental change. *One Earth*, *2*(6), 532–543. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.oneear.2020.05.014

Furtherfield. (2025). *The treaty of finsbury park*. https://www.furtherfield.org/the-treaty-of-finsbury-park-2025-drop-in-session/

Gero, J., & Milovanovic, J. (2022). Creation and characterization of design spaces. *DRS Biennial Conference Series*. https://dl.designresearchsociety.org/drs-conference-papers/drs2022/researchpapers/44

Giaccardi, E., Redström, J., & Nicenboim, I. (2025). The making(s) of more-than-human design: Introduction to the special issue on more-than-human design and HCI. *Human–Computer Interaction*, *40*(1–4), 1–16. https://doi.org/10.1080/07370024.2024.2353357

Guaraldo, E. (2023). *Building common ground ecological art practices and human-nonhuman knowledges: Ecological art practices and human-nonhuman knowledges*. Fondazione Università Ca' Foscari. https://doi.org/10.30687/978-88-6969-756-2

Haraway, D. J. (2016). *Staying with the trouble: Making kin in the chthulucene*. Duke University Press. https://doi.org/10.1215/9780822373780

Heitlinger, S., Light, A., Akama, Y., Lindström, K., & Ståhl, Å. (2025). More-than-human participatory design. In R. C. Smith, D. Loi, H. Winschiers-theophilus, L. Huybrechts, & J. Simonsen (Eds.), *Routledge international handbook of contemporary participatory design*. Routledge.

Hine, D. (2023). *At work in the ruins*. Chelsea Green Publishing Co.

Holroyd, A. T. (2025). *Fashion fictions: Imagining sustainable worlds*. Bloomsbury Academic.

Houston, L., Light, A., & Thornton, C. (2022, June 21). *The richness of designing for eco-social change: Creative practice, transformative futures and living within limits*. Eighth Workshop on Computing within Limits 2022. https://doi.org/10.21428/bf6fb269.eb087907

Jasanoff, S. (2010). A new climate for society. *Theory, Culture & Society*, *27*(2–3), 233–253. https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276409361497

Kimmerer, R. W. (2013). *Braiding sweetgrass: Indigenous wisdom, scientific knowledge and the teachings of plants*. Milkweed Editions.

Klein, N., & Taylor, A. (2025, April 13). The rise of end times fascism. *The Guardian*. https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/ng-interactive/2025/apr/13/end-times-fascism-far-right-trump-musk

Krenak, A. (2020). *Ideas to postpone the end of the world* (A. Doyle, Trans.). Anansi International.

Krpan, D., Basso, F., O'Dell, D., Hickel, J. E., & Kallis, G. (2025). A call for psychological and behavioural science on degrowth. *Nature Human Behaviour*, *9*(8), 1513–1518. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02211-8

Latour, B. (2007). *Reassembling the social: An introduction to actor-network-theory*. Oxford Univ. Press.

Latour, B. (2014). Agency at the time of the Anthropocene. *New Literary History*, *45*(1), 1–18. https://doi.org/10.1353/nlh.2014.0003

Lawrence, G., & Hall, E. (2022). *A report from creative carbon Scotland and the EU CreaTures project.* https://cultureforclimate.scot/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/Transforming-futures-place-based-report_compressed.pdf

Lekkerkerk, N. J., & Burgering, E. (Eds.). (2024). *Worlding ecologies: Art, science and activism towards climate justice*. Valiz.

Light, A. (2015). Troubling futures: Can participatory design research provide a constitutive anthropology for the 21st century? *Interaction Design and Architecture(s)*, *26*, 81–94. https://doi.org/10.55612/s-5002-026-005

Light, A. (2018). Ideas of Autonomía: Buzzwords, borderlands and research through design. *Strategic Design Research Journal*, *11*(2), 147–153.

Light, A. (2021). Collaborative speculation: Anticipation, inclusion and designing counterfactual futures for appropriation. *Futures*, *134*, 102855. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.futures.2021.102855

Light, A. (2023). In dialogue with the more-than-human: Affective prefiguration in encounters with others. *Interactions*, *30*(4), 24–27. https://doi.org/10.1145/3599956

Light, A., Choi, J. H., Houston, L., & Botero, A. (2024). Enacting entanglement: CreaTures, socio-technical collaboration and designing a transformative ethos. *Computer Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW)*, *33*(4), 1223–1259. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10606-024-09497-8

Light, A., & Millen, T. (2026). Participative Intimacy in/as design for coexistence: Affective prefiguration, politics and collaborative futures. *Proceedings of the Participatory Design Conference 2026 (PDC'26)*.

Lineberry, H. S., & Wiek, A. (2016). Art and sustainability. In H. Heinrichs, P. Martens, G. Michelsen, & A. Wiek (Eds.), *Sustainability science: An introduction* (pp. 311–324). Springer Netherlands. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-94-017-7242-6_26

Lopes Ramos, J., Dunne-Howrie, J., Maravala, P. J., & Simon, B. (2020). The post-immersive manifesto. *International Journal of Performance Arts and Digital Media*, *16*(2), 196–212. https://doi.org/10.1080/14794713.2020.1766282

Machado De Oliveira, V. (2021). *Hospicing modernity: Facing humanity's wrongs and the implications for social activism*. North Atlantic Books.

McKenzie, B. (n.d.) Explaining Possitopia. https://bridgetmckenzie.uk/explaining-possitopia

Murphy, J., & Robertson, J. (2025). *Kyoto (Playscript)*. Faber & Faber.

Neal, L. (2015). *Playing for time—Making art as if the world mattered*. Triarchy Press. https://www.triarchypress.net/playing.html

Obura, D., Agrawal, A., Christie, M., Fromentin, J.-M., Harrison, P. A., Jones, M., O'Brien, K., Pauchard, A., Roy, H. E., Settele, J., & Stoett, P. (2026). A systems reset

for sustainable development. *Communications Sustainability*, *1*(1), 3. https://doi.org/10.1038/s44458-025-00009-3

Papadopoulos, D. (2018). *Experimental practice: Technoscience, alterontologies and more-than-social movements*. Duke University Press. https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv1220jd3

Punchdrunk. (n.d.). *Punchdrunk*. Retrieved January 7, 2026, from https://www.punchdrunk.com/

Rancière, J. (2004). *The politics of aesthetics: The distribution of the sensible* (G. Rockhill, Ed.). Continuum International.

Raven, P. G., & Stripple, J. (2021). Touring the carbon ruins: Towards an ethics of speculative decarbonisation. *Global Discourse*, *11*(1–2), 221–240. https://doi.org/10.1332/204378920X16052078001915

Ritchie, P. D. L., Clarke, J. J., Cox, P. M., & Huntingford, C. (2021). Overshooting tipping point thresholds in a changing climate. *Nature*, *592*(7855), 517–523. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-021-03263-2

SIMD. (2020). *SIMD (Scottish Index of Multiple Deprivation)*. Scottish Index of Multiple Deprivation. http://simd.scot/

Supran, G., & Oreskes, N. (2021). Rhetoric and frame analysis of ExxonMobil's climate change communications. *One Earth*, *4*(5), 696–719. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.oneear.2021.04.014

Taeoalii-Tipton, D. (2025). *UN report confirms breaching 1.5 C global warming | Union of concerned scientists*. https://www.ucs.org/about/news/un-report-confirms-breaching-15-c-global-warming

Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979). An integrative theory of intergroup conflict. In J. A. Williams & S. Worchel (Eds.), *The social psychology of intergroup relations* (pp. 33–47). Wadsworth.

Thornton, C. (2024, February 6). Social Spa for Collective Mutation [Substack newsletter]. *News from The FED (The Feminist Economics Department)*. https://feministecondept.substack.com/p/social-spa-for-collective-mutation

Tsing, A. L., Bubandt, N., Gan, E., & Swanson, H. A. (2017). *Arts of living on a damaged planet: Ghosts and monsters of the anthropocene*. University of Minnesota Press.

Turner, V. (1974). Liminal to liminoid, in play, flow, and ritual: An essay in comparative symbology. *Rice Institute Pamphlet - Rice University Studies*, *60*(3). https://hdl.handle.net/1911/63159

Van Gennep, A. (1960). *The rites of passage*. University of Chicago Press. https://doi.org/10.7208/chicago/9780226629520.001.0001

van Zomeren, M., Postmes, T., & Spears, R. (2008). Toward an integrative social identity model of collective action: A quantitative research synthesis of three socio-psychological perspectives. *Psychological Bulletin*, *134*(4), 504–535. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033–2909.134.4.504

Vervoort, J. M., Smeenk, T., Zamuruieva, I., Reichelt, L. L., Veldhoven, M. van, Rutting, L., Light, A., Houston, L., Wolstenholme, R., Dolejšová, M., Jain, A., Ardern, J., Catlow, R., Vaajakallio, K., Flittner, Z. F. von, Putrle-Srdić, J., Lohmann, J. C., Moossdorff, C., Mattelmäki, T., … Mangnus, A. C. (2024). 9 dimensions for evaluating how art and creative practice stimulate societal transformations. *Ecology and Society*, *29*(1). https://doi.org/10.5751/ES-14739-290129

Vestergren, S., Eckerle, F., Acar, Y. G., Clarke, D., Clarke, E. J. R., & Uysal, M. S. (2026). Beyond the politics of demand: Prefigurative politics and the future of collective action research. PsyArXiv. https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/h2up6_v1

Weintraub, L. (2012). *To life!: Eco art in pursuit of a sustainable planet*. University of California Press.

White, G. (2013). *Audience participation in theatre: Aesthetics of the invitation*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Wolf Willow. (n.d.). *Who we are*. Wolf Willow. Retrieved January 27, 2026, from https://www.wolfwillow.org/who-we-are

Yusoff, K., & Gabrys, J. (2011). Climate change and the imagination. *WIREs Climate Change*, *2*(4), 516–534. https://doi.org/10.1002/wcc.117

Zurek, M., Hebinck, A., & Selomane, O. (2022). Climate change and the urgency to transform food systems. *Science*, *376*(6600), 1416–1421. https://doi.org/10.1126/science.abo2364